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Ezra

Ezra 3:1–7

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 3:1–7 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

King Cyrus was king of Persia at the time of this story, and Cyrus gave the Israelites permission to travel back to the land of Israel. In the previous passage, the storyteller provided a list of families who traveled back to Israel. This story is about how the Israelites obey Yahweh's laws again. The story shows us how the Israelites have returned to Israel and to praising Yahweh the way Yahweh commanded.

The Israelites finished moving into their towns in the seventh month of the year. The Israelites often prepared to gather their crops during the seventh month of the year, which is September or October in our calendar. The seventh month is important to the Israelites because Yahweh commanded the Israelites to celebrate many special events in this month. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to celebrate many of these special events because each one reminded the Israelites of all the ways Yahweh had taken care of them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your culture keep track of the days and months? What are some important times of year in your culture? Pause this audio here.

After the Israelites finished moving, the entire group of Israelites met in Jerusalem because they all wanted to start rebuilding Yahweh's temple. At that time, a man named Jeshua was the leader of the priests, and a man named Zerubbabel was a leader of the Israelites. Jeshua and Zerubbabel were the leaders of the construction project, and they started by building Yahweh's altar. Israelites used the altar to give important gifts to Yahweh. Because Yahweh's gifts were very important, Jeshua and Zerubbabel started building the altar first so they could give Yahweh gifts before the Israelites finished the temple. The Israelites probably built the altar using stones and made a flat surface on top that they would use to burn animals as a gift to Yahweh. The Israelites would give these gifts to Yahweh every morning and every night. On special days, the Israelites would give more gifts to Yahweh in the way Yahweh commanded the people.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel and find Jerusalem as a group. Notice where the Israelites would have needed to travel to build the temple. Look at a picture of an altar as a group and talk about similar objects that people in your culture may use in religious or cultural ceremonies. Pause this audio here.

Several groups of local people were living in the area when the Israelites moved back into Israel. Some of these groups of people were the Ammonites, Samaritans, Moabites, and Edomites, and they had fought and disagreed with the Israelites for hundreds of years. You will remember that the Samaritans were the Israelites

who were from the Northern Kingdom of Israel. The Samaritans had not followed Yahweh, and Yahweh had allowed foreign countries to conquer them. These people did not follow Yahweh the way Yahweh instructed and were unfriendly to the Israelites when they tried to build the altar. The storyteller does not explain why these local people were not friendly to the Israelites, but it could be because they disagreed with the Israelites on how and where the Israelites built the altar. The most important thing to know is that the Israelites were afraid because of the local people, but the Israelites chose to build the altar anyway.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When was a time you were afraid of something but chose to act anyway? What happened as a result? Pause this audio here.

After the Israelites finished building the altar, the Israelites started celebrating the special religious events Yahweh commanded the Israelites to celebrate during the seventh month of the year. One of these events is called the Festival of Tabernacles. This celebration reminded the Israelites about how Yahweh had saved them when they were slaves in Egypt many centuries before this story. During the Festival of Booths, Israelite families would make tents out of tree branches and live in the tents for eight days. While the Israelites lived in tents for eight days, the priests would make a special burnt offering to Yahweh on each day of the celebration.

Stop here and look at a picture of a tent that the Israelites would make for the Festival of Booths celebration. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites also started celebrating the Festival of the New Moon again. The Israelites celebrated this festival at the beginning of every month when they saw the new moon rise in the sky. The Israelites would celebrate by blowing trumpets and making burnt offerings to thank Yahweh for the new month.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story of a time when you celebrated a new beginning. Pause this audio here.

When the Israelites started celebrating the festivals again, the Israelites also started making the usual burnt sacrifices to Yahweh as Yahweh had commanded in the law. The Israelites also made sacrifices to Yahweh that Yahweh did not require. The Israelites made these “freewill” sacrifices just because they were very thankful to Yahweh for taking care of the Israelites. It is important to understand why the Israelites were giving Yahweh sacrifices because it shows that the Israelites were focusing on worshipping Yahweh even though they had not built the temple yet.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of events does your culture view as important to remember? What does your culture do to remember these events? Pause this audio here.

The Israelites now have an altar, but the Israelites still do not have a temple. To build the temple, the Israelites gave money to the “masons,” or people who cut stones, and to the “carpenters,” or people who made things from wood for building. The Israelites also gave oil, wine, and food to the Sidonians and Tyrians. The Sidonians and Tyrians were people from a region next to Israel. In exchange for the supplies and money, the Sidonians and Tyrians gave the Israelites cedar trees. You will remember that the Israelites used the cedar trees from the Sidonians and Tyrians to build Yahweh’s first temple many centuries before this story. To send the cedar trees to the Israelites, the Sidonians and Tyrians tied the logs together and floated the logs on the sea to Joppa. It is important to know that Joppa is a city in Israel that is close to the sea. Then the Israelites would bring the logs a long distance over the land to Jerusalem. The Israelites could do all this work to rebuild the temple because King Cyrus gave them special permission.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cedar tree. Note the size and shape of the logs. Also, look at a map of the trading route the Israelites used to get what they needed to build the temple.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The Israelites finish moving into their towns and decide to meet in Jerusalem. Then Jeshua and Zerubbabel help the Israelites start building the altar. The Israelites are afraid of the local people but continue to work on the altar anyway.

In the second scene: The Israelites finish building the altar, and the Israelites start making sacrifices to Yahweh. The Israelites also start celebrating festivals like the Festival of Booths and the Festival of the New Moon again.

In the third scene: The Israelites want to start building the temple. The Israelites give money to stone and wood workers to build the temple. The Israelites also give supplies to the Sidonians and Tyrians in exchange for special cedar trees.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelites
- The local people
- Jeshua, the lead priest
- Zerubbabel, a leader of the Israelites
- Yahweh
- Wood workers
- Stone workers
- Sidonians
- And Tyrians

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the Israelites finish moving into their towns and decide to meet in Jerusalem. The storyteller says that the Israelites all gathered as one. This means that because all the Israelites agreed that it was important to meet together to build the temple, it was like one person had made the decision. The storyteller uses this phrase to explain that the Israelites felt very unified in their decision. This is important because it shows that all of the Israelites thought it was important to start worshipping Yahweh again.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about people gathering in your language? Pause the audio here.

The Israelites meet in Jerusalem in the seventh month of the year. The storyteller uses these words to give background to the story and to explain that something new is starting.

Stop here and tell a story to the group that includes a time of year when an event begins. Pause the audio here.

The Israelite's decision to meet in Jerusalem is the first thing the Israelites do when they have settled in Israel. When the Israelites arrive in Jerusalem, Jeshua the priest and Zerubbabel the leader take charge of the construction of the altar.

The Israelites were scared of the people around them when they built the altar. Some people say that the reason the Israelites built the altar to Yahweh is that the Israelites were scared of the local people. Some other people say that the Israelites were already scared of the local people and built the altar despite their fear. We do not know which opinion is correct, but we know for sure that the Israelites were scared of the local people when the Israelites built the altar.

Stop here and discuss your choice as a group. Why do you think the Israelites were afraid? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, after the Israelites build the altar, the Israelites start to make sacrifices and worship Yahweh. The order of this scene can be hard to follow. The Israelites build the altar first and then start to offer daily morning and evening sacrifices to Yahweh on the first day of the seventh month. Although the storyteller first talks about the most important festival in the seventh month, the Festival of Tabernacles, this festival does not happen until later in the month. Instead, the Israelites probably celebrate the Festival of the New Moon first at the beginning of the month and begin offering all the regular, daily burnt offerings that Yahweh required in his law. The Israelites celebrate the Festival of Tabernacles later in the month after the Festival of the New Moon.

Stop here and tell a story to the group. Pay attention to how you tell the story. How do you explain to the audience what order the events happened in? Pause this audio here.

Throughout the seventh month, the Israelites also celebrate other festivals the way Yahweh had commanded. Some of the Israelites even choose to bring some optional sacrifices for Yahweh simply because they are thankful. The storyteller is very clear that the Israelites begin to celebrate all the festivals and special events the same way Yahweh said to do in the law he gave to Moses, and that Moses wrote down. In other words, the Israelites do all these things to obey what “was written” in Scripture. This means that the Israelites obey Yahweh and follow Yahweh’s commands well.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you explain that something was done the right way in your culture? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the Israelites have been making sacrifices to Yahweh, but still have not built the base of the temple. When the Israelites built a building, the Israelites had to put down a strong base before they built the walls and roof. The Israelites may have built this base from large, strong stones. This kept the building strong and helped it to last longer.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words do you use to describe the base of a building? What words do you use to describe the parts of a building that make it stand strong? Pause this audio here.

So, the Israelites decide to build the temple. The Israelites need people to make the temple, so they give money to stonecutters and woodworkers. Masons, or stonecutters, are people who work with stone to make buildings. Carpenters, or woodworkers, are people who work with wood for buildings or furnishings. At the same time, the Israelites give food, wine, and oil to the Sidonians and Tyrians in exchange for the cedar trees that the Israelites use to make the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call people who work with stone and wood in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelites
- The local people
- Jeshua, the lead priest
- Zerubbabel, a leader of the Israelites
- Yahweh
- Wood workers

- Stone workers
- Sidonians
- And Tyrians

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In scene one, the people playing the Israelites finish moving into their homes and travel to Jerusalem because they want to build the temple. The people playing Jeshua and Zerubbabel lead the Israelites as they build the altar, even though the Israelites are scared of the local people.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am excited to be worshiping Yahweh again! or
- I am scared that the local people around us will kill us.

Ask the person playing the local people, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- The Israelites told us we could not help them build the temple, and now we are angry that the Israelites are building the altar without us; or
- The Israelites took away our land. Now, the Israelites are building an altar, which must mean the Israelites will stay here. That makes us angry!

Ask the people playing Jeshua and Zerubbabel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We must worship Yahweh again, as Yahweh commanded us. We must help the Israelites follow Yahweh!

Continue the drama.

In scene two, the people playing the Israelites start making daily sacrifices to Yahweh and celebrating the Festival of Tabernacles and the Festival of the New Moon. Some of the people playing the Israelites can also choose to bring their own sacrifice to the altar to show their thankfulness to Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I love my people so much, and it makes me so happy that they are obeying me again.

Ask the person playing the Israelites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so thankful that Yahweh has brought us back into Israel! or
- Following Yahweh is a lot of work! or
- I am so happy that I can worship Yahweh again the way he commanded us to; or
- I hope that Yahweh saves us from the anger of the people around us.

Continue the drama.

In scene three, the people playing the Israelites give money and supplies to the woodworkers, stonecutters, and the Sidonians and Tyrians to build the temple. The people playing the Sidonians and Tyrians then float cedar trees on the sea so that the Israelites can use the trees for the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, “What are you feeling and thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- The first temple to Yahweh was much more beautiful. I am so sad that we cannot give Yahweh more; or
- I am so happy that we can finally give Yahweh a temple again!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The storyteller mentions that in the seventh month of the year, the people of **Israel** lived in their towns. Israel is the name of the territory where the Israelites lived. Israel also refers to one of Abraham’s sons, who was named Israel. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

The Israelites moved into **towns** in Israel after King Cyrus of Persia gave them permission to leave. Use the same word or phrase for towns as you used in previous passages.

The Israelites decided to meet in **Jerusalem** to rebuild Yahweh’s temple. Jerusalem is one of the most important cities in Israel. For more information on Jerusalem, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Jerusalem as you used in previous passages.

Jeshua and Zerubbabel built the altar to Yahweh with the help of their relatives, associates, fellow priests, or brothers. The people were other priests and maybe some regular Israelites who worked with Jeshua and Zerubbabel to build the altar. Some of these people were probably relatives, or part of Jeshua and Zerubbabel’s brothers and close family, and some may have just been other Israelites who wanted to help.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **priests**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites built an altar to Yahweh in Jerusalem. An altar is a place where people make many kinds of offerings to Yahweh. The Israelites would often make altars with stones and with a flat surface on top.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **altar**. Look up altar in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites built an altar to the **God** of Israel. In the Bible, God refers to God who is powerful and created the whole world. It is the same God who made promises to Abraham. God is also the same God that the Israelites have worshipped for many centuries. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

A burnt offering is a specific form of sacrifice. A priest burned the plants or animals that people meant to give to Yahweh. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to give burnt offerings in special ways in the Old Testament.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **burnt offering**. Look up burnt offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites built the altar and made sacrifices on it according to the Law of Moses. The Law of Moses is the law that Yahweh gave to Moses that explains how the Israelites should live. The law tells the Israelites how

to worship Yahweh and how to treat the people around them. “According to the Law of Moses” in this story means that the Israelites gave Yahweh sacrifices in the way Yahweh commanded.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **law**. Look up law in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites made offerings and sacrifices to **Yahweh**. Yahweh is a name for God that God gave Moses many centuries before this story. The name Yahweh reminds the Israelites of God’s promises to the Israelites. This name reminds everyone that God never changes and always keeps his promises. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

The Israelites celebrated the “Festival of Tabernacles” or “Festival of Booths.” It was a special event that the Israelites celebrated to remember when Yahweh saved them from slavery in Egypt many centuries before this story. During the Festival of Tabernacles, the Israelites set up tents and lived in them for eight days. The Israelites celebrated this event to remember when their ancestors had walked in the desert for many years before moving into Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **Festival of Tabernacles**. Look up “Festival of Tabernacles” in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites also celebrated the “New Moon festival.” In Old Testament times, the people of Israel celebrated this festival at the beginning of each month, when the people could see the new moon rise in the sky. During this festival, the Israelites stopped their work, offered special sacrifices, and blew trumpets to celebrate.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the **New Moon Festival**. Refer to “Festival of New Moon” in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites made sacrifices to Yahweh and celebrated all the **appointed festivals of Yahweh**. The appointed festivals of Yahweh are the festivals that Yahweh commanded the Israelites to celebrate.

The Israelites chose to give Yahweh “freewill offerings” when they started celebrating Yahweh’s festivals again. A freewill offering is another specific form of sacrifice. A freewill offering is a sacrifice that the Israelites would bring to Yahweh when they were thankful for Yahweh. It is important to know that Yahweh does not require the Israelites to make freewill offerings.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **freewill offering**. Look up freewill offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites gave sacrifices to Yahweh even though they had not built the foundation of the temple yet. A foundation is the base of a building. People build a foundation first to make a building stable and strong for a long time.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **foundation**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites met in Jerusalem because they wanted to build Yahweh’s **temple**. The temple is a place in Jerusalem that the Israelites built so that they could worship Yahweh as he commanded. The “house of God” is another name for the temple. King Solomon first built the temple many centuries before this story. After King Cyrus gave the Israelites permission to move into Israel again, the Israelites wanted to rebuild the temple so that they could start worshipping Yahweh again. For more information on the temple, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for temple as you used in previous passages.

After the Israelites built the altar, they gave money to masons and carpenters to build Yahweh's temple. Masons and carpenters are people who have special skills to work with different kinds of supplies. Masons cut and shape stones and rocks, and carpenters cut and shape wood. Masons and carpenters both use their skills to make buildings and objects.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **masons** and **carpenters**. Discuss what you call people who build with stone and wood in your culture. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites gave wine, oil, and food to the Sidonians and Tyrians in exchange for cedar trees to build the temple. Wine is a drink that people make from fermented grape juice. Grapes are small, soft, and juicy berries that grow in several different colors.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wine**. Look up wine in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller mentions that **King** Cyrus of Persia gave special permission for the Israelites to get cedar trees from the Sidonians and Tyrians. A king is a special person who rules over a city or area. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.